INTERNET FOR ALL: Ways To Achieve

A Project Loon balloon on its way to Puerto Rico from the launch site in Nevada (Source: Google)

Janani Gopalakrishnan Vikram is a technically-qualified freelance writer, editor and hands-on mom based in Chennai

Take a look at the many options that are being considered globally to connect remote areas affordably

At a time when we use the Internet for everything from communications and education to shopping and navigation, millions of people across the world live several kilometres away from base stations without access to mobile networks. In rugged terrains and interior regions, laying cables is also too costly, making broadband connectivity impossible. According to a UN report, this leaves nearly half the world's population 'unconnected'!

However, people in remote areas need the Internet as much as us. Farmers can use the Internet to manage their crops better and sell their produce. Rural artisans can peddle their ware directly instead of selling cheap to middlemen. Education, women empowerment, economy, healthcare, sanitation and many other facets of life will get a positive spin. This makes it imperative to connect the rest of the world's population to this magical realm called the Internet.

But, that's easier said than done. It will take years to extend the kind of communications infrastructure we have in cities and towns to remote areas—because of the difficulties posed by weather and geographical terrains, the sheer cost of setting up cable or mobile networks across hundreds of kilometres, learning curves involved in using the infrastructure, poor economy of scale, slow returns on the investment and more of such risks.

As a result, governments, researchers and socially responsible corporates have started exploring alternate methods to connect remote areas across the world. From hoisting mobile infrastructure on hot-air balloons and drones, to using vacant television bandwidth for connectivity, a lot of mind-boggling ideas are being explored.

The Indian government is also working towards similar goals with its Digital India campaign. Although progress seemed slow initially, it has taken conscious efforts last year to speed up the related infrastructure development. Connectivity to Indian villages was one of the key focus areas of Budget 2017. Last year, Minister of Communications, Manoj Sinha announced that all 250,000 Gram Panchayats in India will be connected to the Internet by December 2018 under the BharatNet project. Earlier known as the National Optic Fibre Network or NOFN, this project will cost ₹ 100 billion. Along with optical fibre networks, Wi-Fi hotspots are also being set up in every village.